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Cold War, Hot Merch: The Stendahl Art Galleries and the Art of Cultural Diplomacy

Kylie G. King & Payton P. Quintanilla

Introduction

In August 1939, the Stendahl Art Galleries of Los Angeles, California (henceforward, SAG), exhibited Picasso's *Guernica* (painted in 1937 in response to the bombing of that Basque town by Fascist German and Italian forces) just weeks before the outbreak of World War II. Capitalizing on a climate already primed by conservative commentators’ alarm over the spectre of “Foreign Influence” in the United States, as reported in the press by journalists such as Alma May Cook, attendance was fanned by a campaign that cast avant-garde art as a threat to national values (Cook, 12 Aug. 1939, SAGRa b1f12; see also Turner et al. 2026, 23-24; Schieder 2024, 190–92). Earl Stendahl did not shy away from propagandistic publicity tactics to evoke interest in his exhibitions, embracing the advertising campaign for *Guernica* initiated by the Motion Picture Artists’ Committee (MPAC), which sponsored the exhibition’s Southern Californian iteration (MPAC 1939). At the conclusion of the tour, MPAC’s Executive Secretary reported: “We had a very capable publicity man who succeeded in stirring up a ‘sanity in art’ controversy in the metropolitan press which created terrific interest in the exhibit” (Marcelene Peterson to Evelyn Ahrend, 2 September 1939, SRRAR 1935-1957, Part B, box 25; pers. comm. Michael Mathiowetz, 18 Jul. 2026). While the exhibition campaign reportedly did not translate into financial benefit for Spanish orphans whose cause it ostensibly supported, it did enhance the visibility and standing of the galleries involved—and the benefit of an association with the eponymous gallery of Sidney Janis, the prominent New York City dealer and chairman of the Picasso Exhibition Committee, was surely not lost on Earl (see also Turner et al. 2026, 25).[1]

[1] The aforementioned article by Schieder briefly discusses the negative press surrounding the painting’s display in Los Angeles, citing, in particular, a letter from fellow Los Angeles-based collector and dealer Galka Scheyer to Sidney Janis, in which she described the remarks as “very common and vulgar,” but acknowledged that they would nonetheless help publicize the exhibition (Scheyer to Janis, 2 Sept. 1939, cited in Schieder 2024, 192).

The *Guernica* episode evidences Stendahl's interest in leveraging both "publicity and prestige" (John Sherman to Marcelene Peterson, 9 Sept. 1939, SRAR, 1935–1957, box 25: Picasso Tour) and sociopolitics for professional and commercial gain. Less than two decades later, Stendahl turned that same instinct for politically charged spectacle toward Cold War propaganda when, in December 1956, he applied for exhibition funding from the newly founded United States Information Agency (USIA). This time, rather than bringing modern European art imbued with an anti-fascist message to conservative-leaning, pre-war Southern California, he proposed taking Latin American antiquities—the cultural patrimony of the US' southern neighbors—to ideologically-divided post-war Europe. Established by President Dwight D. Eisenhower amid escalating Cold War tensions, the agency's principal stated mission, as per the 1953 'Directive Approved by the President for the Guidance of the United States Information Agency,' was "to submit evidence to people of other nations by means of communication techniques that the objectives and policies of the United States are in harmony with and will advance their legitimate aspirations for freedom, progress and peace" (cited in Wulf 2015, 56). In practice, however, a major component of its purview was to quash pro-communist sentiment by cultivating anti-Soviet attitudes through strategic cultural outreach (see Luke and Kersel 2013, 6-7).

Curating Soft Power

Stendahl leveraged this propagandistic mission in his USIA application (fig. 1), proposing a touring exhibition of pre-Columbian material brought together under the guise of bringing "the New World" to Europeans. Aligning himself explicitly with Eisenhower's initiative, Stendahl begins starkly by setting out "THE PROBLEM"—that is, the "Soviet cultural offensive in Europe"—which he claimed had "strained ties" with the United States. As a remedy, he proposed a large-scale exhibition of 3,500 pre-Columbian artworks drawn from the SAG inventory and private US-based collections,[2] which would travel to multiple venues across Europe (Earl Stendahl to James Raymond West, 7 Dec. 1956, SAGRb, b86f4). However, Stendahl's underlying objective was the creation of a cultural event that would lead to commercial gains. In other words, he sought to establish a market for pre-Columbian material

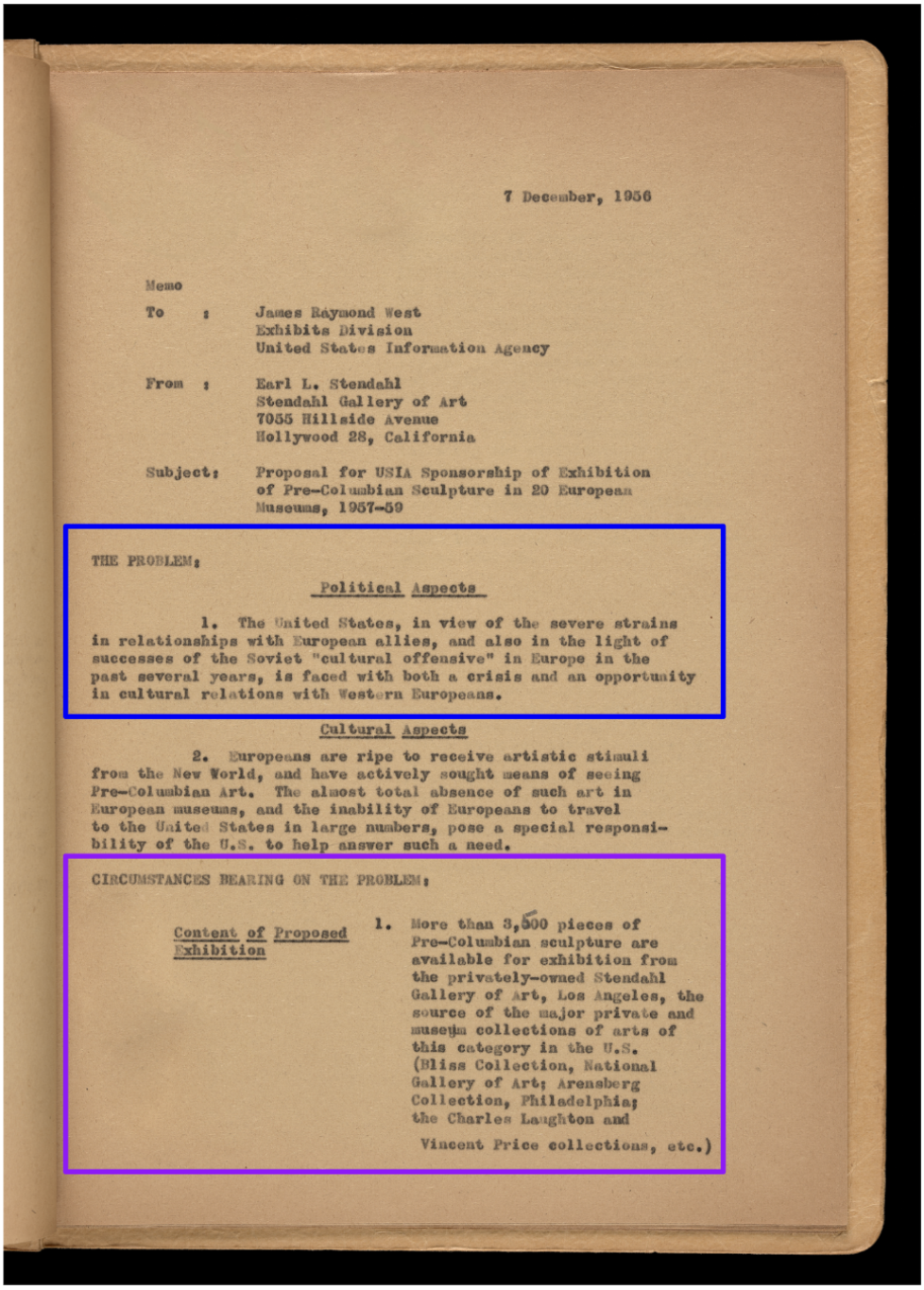
[2] While the crux of the argument remained unchanged, the version of the application ultimately submitted excised some details, including the explicit identification of the collections from which Stendahl proposed to borrow objects for display alongside his own stock. The original submission, for example, listed the "[Robert Woods and Mildred] Bliss Collection, [Walter and Louise] Arensberg [Collection], National Gallery of Art [Washington, D.C.], Philadelphia [Museum of Art], Charles Laughton [Collection]," etc. (Earl Stendahl to James Raymond West, 18 Dec. 1956, SAGRb b86f4).

on the other side of the Atlantic, while also sourcing diverse materials from European and Middle Eastern collections to sell in the United States (see also King et al., forthcoming; O'Neil and Miller 2023).

Indeed, in Stendahl's pursuit of US government patronage, the language of cultural and public diplomacy obscures the desire for personal profit through his carefully—even, altruistically—worded rationale for the application (Earl Stendahl to James Raymond West, 7 Dec. 1956, SAGRb, b86f4):

> Europeans are ripe to receive artistic stimuli from the New World, and have actively sought means of seeing Pre-Columbian Art. The almost total absence of such art in European museums, and the inability of Europeans to travel to the United States in large numbers, pose a special responsibility of the U.S. to help answer such a need.

The application was submitted by the American Federation of Arts (AFA), a non-profit organization dedicated to touring art exhibitions in the US and abroad. Tellingly, Stendahl's proposed exhibition of Latin American antiquities followed the government's refusal to sponsor overseas exhibitions that included paintings made after 1917—the year of the Russian Revolution (Distel 2019, 19). Might Stendahl have recalled the publicity generated by the conservative "Sanity in Art" movement in 1939, whose proponents warned that modern art embodied a "destructive Bolshevist influence" (Millier 1939)? In any case, it is suggestive that Stendahl recognized that the anti-Soviet sentiment could be mobilized to generate government and public support, and, therefore, clients.



7 December, 1956

Memo

To : James Raymond West
Exhibits Division
United States Information Agency

From : Earl L. Stendahl
Stendahl Gallery of Art
7055 Hillside Avenue
Hollywood 28, California

Subject: Proposal for USIA Sponsorship of Exhibition of Pre-Columbian Sculpture in 20 European Museums, 1957-59

THE PROBLEM:

Political Aspects

1. The United States, in view of the severe strains in relationships with European allies, and also in the light of successes of the Soviet "cultural offensive" in Europe in the past several years, is faced with both a crisis and an opportunity in cultural relations with Western Europeans.

Cultural Aspects

2. Europeans are ripe to receive artistic stimuli from the New World, and have actively sought means of seeing Pre-Columbian Art. The almost total absence of such art in European museums, and the inability of Europeans to travel to the United States in large numbers, pose a special responsibility of the U.S. to help answer such a need.

CIRCUMSTANCES BEARING ON THE PROBLEM:

Content of Proposed Exhibition

1. More than 3,500 pieces of Pre-Columbian sculpture are available for exhibition from the privately-owned Stendahl Gallery of Art, Los Angeles, the source of the major private and museum collections of arts of this category in the U.S. (Bliss Collection, National Gallery of Art; Arensberg Collection, Philadelphia; the Charles Laughton and Vincent Price collections, etc.)

Fig. 1: Exhibition proposal to James Raymond West of the USIA, December 7, 1956 [page 1], 1956. Stendahl Art Galleries Archive. Getty Research Institute, Los Angeles (2017.M.38), Gift of April and Ronald Dammann.

Stendahl's proposal presents as a distorted and paternalistic attempt to mimic a very specific program of Mexican cultural diplomacy: state-sponsored exhibitions of Mexican art that travelled not only to the United States but also throughout Europe, and which would eventually venture into the Eastern Bloc. The director of these exhibitions was the now storied museologist Fernando Gamboa, who the art historian Ana Garduño has called "el curador de la Guerra Fría" (the curator of the Cold War) (Garduño 2009, 65).

Exhibiting Public Diplomacy

Long before organizing international tours, Gamboa worked both within and outside of the state apparatus to actively nurture art education and appreciation at home in Mexico. His efforts often included, and arguably necessitated, public-private partnerships, such as the exhibitions of the Sociedad de Arte Moderno (SAM). Filling a gap in the curatorial programme of Mexico City's Palace of Fine Arts, curators, collectors, dealers, artists, scholars, and government administrators joined forces to mount a series of public exhibitions featuring objects from institutional as well as private collections (Garduño 2007).

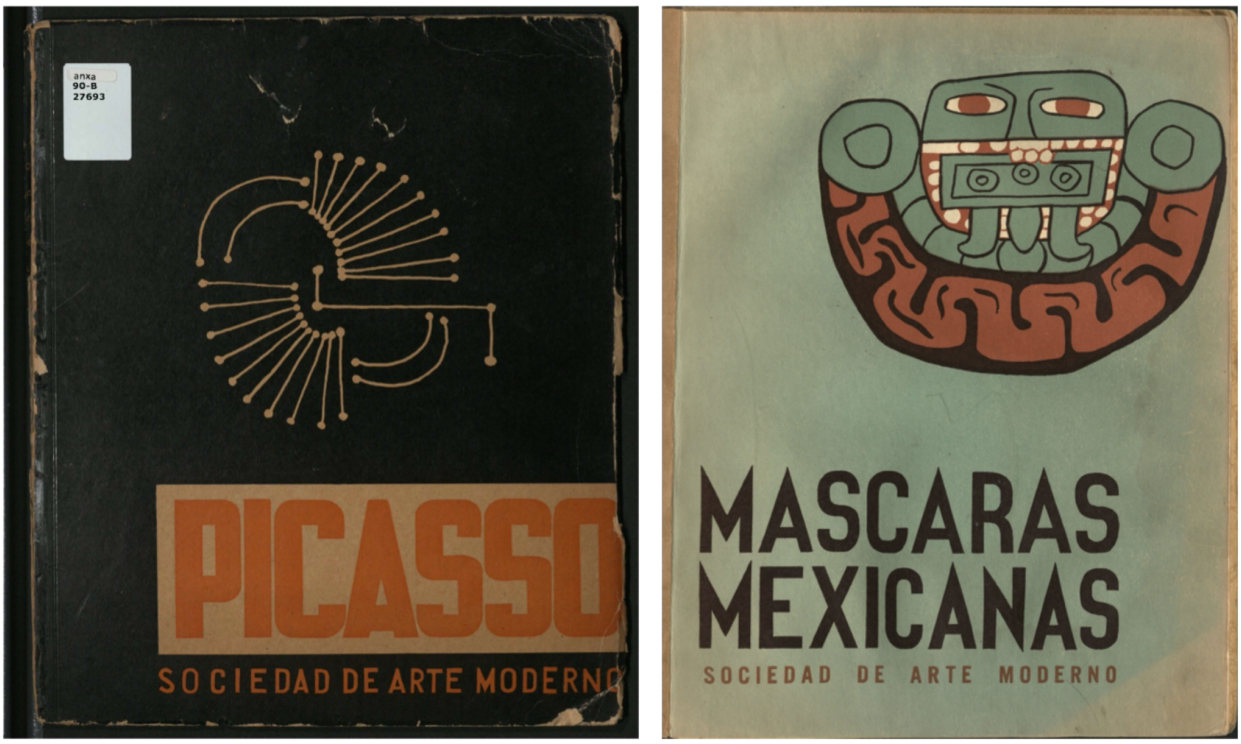


Fig. 2a-b: Catalogue for the exhibition *Picasso*, Sociedad de Arte Moderno, Mexico City, 1944 and

Catalogue for the exhibition *Máscaras Mexicanas*, Sociedad de Arte Moderno, Mexico City, 1945.[3]

The SAM's first exhibition, on the art of Pablo Picasso, opened in 1944, and included a number of loans from US collectors and institutions (Sociedad de Arte Moderno 1944, 4, 41–42). Gamboa served on the Organizing Committee (4). The catalogue's introductory text argued that, with Europe in ruins, Mexico was positioned to step into the role of one of the world's great cultural centers (5). The authors insisted that their decision to show the work of a Spaniard did not reflect any sort of "servilismo" (servilism) toward Europe, but rather a recognition of the universal and revolutionary nature of Picasso's inter-war corpus. The SAM could not display Picasso's *Guernica*—then stewarded, along with other materials from Picasso's own collection, by the Museum of Modern Art in New York—due to a laundry-list of reservations that ranged from the logistical to the political (see Marcín Álvarez and Molina P. 2023 and Garduño 2024). It did, however, present sixteen original studies and preparatory sketches of the work (Sociedad de Arte Moderno 1944, 42, 69; Dossier on the Exhibition at the Sociedad de Arte Moderno, 1944, MOMA Exhs. 258.j.1). The sketches, even in the absence of the mural, must have been a particularly meaningful inclusion for Gamboa, given his engagement with Spanish Republicans and other refugees both during and after the Civil War (Gamboa 2016, 229-239).

Stendahl was well aware of the Picasso exhibition, as the collector–dealer Guillermo Echániz, his first significant associate in Mexico, had mentioned it in a letter, in which he also attempted to sell Stendahl a copper plate etched by Picasso that was supposedly slated for display (Guillermo Echániz to Earl Stendahl, [1944], SAGRb b11f7). Stendahl did not accept the offer, but still identified an angle to potentially profit from the exhibition. In his response to Echániz he wrote, "It would be well to get photographs of the Picasso paintings that will be shown as we might be able to buy some" (Earl Stendahl to Guillermo Echániz, 20 Jul. 1944, SAGRb b11f7).

The following year, in 1945, the SAM mounted a new exhibition, *Máscaras Mexicanas* (fig. 2b) (Sociedad de Arte Moderno, 1945), about which Echániz, now as a lender, wrote to Stendahl (Guillermo Echániz to Earl Stendahl, 30 Apr. 1945, SAGRb, b11f7)—and later sold

[3] While we have not been able to identify the artwork on the cover of the SAM's *Picasso* catalogue, it appears to be related to his 1924 "constellation" drawings (for more on these drawings, see, for instance, Karmel 2023). The image on the cover of the *Máscaras mexicanas* catalogue is adapted from a detail of a pre-Hispanic mural rediscovered at Tetitla, Teotihuacan, just a few years prior to this exhibition (O'Neil et al., forthcoming).

him the mask that he lent for display (Inv. No. 2186, Stendahl Inventory Book, SAGRb b91f6).[4] Gamboa was again on the Organizing Committee, and *Máscaras Mexicanas* embodied his vision for expansive exhibitions of Mexican materials, spanning pre-Hispanic to contemporary. The Committee pertinently argued that "artistas modernos" (modern artists) were the ones who had discovered the beauty of pre-Hispanic art (Sociedad de Arte Moderno 1945, 8). This, of course, was the model for MoMA's 1940 exhibition *Twenty Centuries of Mexican Art = Veinte siglos de arte mexicano*, for which co-curator Miguel Covarrubias, in his catalogue texts, included Gamboa among Mexico's contemporary artists (141, 145, 186, 193). It also served as the model for *Arte mexicano desde los tiempos precolombinos hasta nuestros días*, which Gamboa launched in Paris in 1952 (*Art mexicain du précolombien à nos jours*, at the Musée National d'Art Moderne), before it continued on to Stockholm (*Mexikansk konst från forntid till nutid*, at Liljevalchs Konsthall) and London (*Mexican Art: from Pre-Columbian Times to the Present Day*, at the Tate Gallery).

Gamboa promoted and justified the temporary displacement of Mexican patrimony to Europe by reasoning that "Algunos europeos habrán tenido la oportunidad de ver exposiciones nuestras en los Estados Unidos, pero la mayoría no" (Some Europeans will have had the opportunity to see our exhibitions in the United States, but the majority have not) (La Prensa 1951, 12). Stendahl later appropriated this argument, even somewhat replicating its language, in his application to USIA (fig. 1). However, while Stendahl would attempt to paint himself as a vaguely Pan-American cultural ambassador for the United States, Gamboa was recognized as such internationally. Indeed, after his show had opened in Paris in June 1952, UNESCO ran a 7-page spread on the exhibition, which Stendahl retained in his own archive (Cassou 1952, SAGRb, b119f9).

By this time, the Stendahls' interest in Gamboa's tour was highly piqued, so much so that Earl's son, Alfred Stendahl, wrote to Echániz that same month to request a catalogue from the Paris show. Alfred explained later in the letter, "We have been doing a little busiess [*sic*] in

[4] An annotation in the Stendahl Inventory Book notes the presence of this mask in the *Máscaras Mexicanas* catalogue (p. 27, cat no. 8). Such references illustrate a longstanding art-market practice, through which exhibition histories could establish provenance while conferring pedigree to the object through association with prominent collectors, dealers, and government actors. The continued value of such resources for provenance research is, moreover, demonstrated by Barr and Budrovich's recent "Case Study: A Cinerary Urn and Lid," in which they show how references in/to secondary publications can help to reconstruct the otherwise undocumented movements of the objects—in this case, an Etruscan object that passed through Stendahl's hands in the 1960s (Barr and Budrovich 2026, 64).

the painting line and find that our supply in that field is running low. The modern art we have always moves but it has been used more as a background for the P.C. [pre-Columbian]" (Alfred Stendahl to Guillermo Echániz, 13 Jun. 1952, SAGRb, b11f7). It may never be known whether he and his father were already formulating their plan to source paintings in Europe while exhibiting pre-Hispanic materials there (King et al., forthcoming), but the juxtaposition is very suggestive. Either way, Echániz' summary of the show for Alfred Stendahl casts a cynical light on the exchange. On August 3, 1952, he wrote, "Of course, you have learned all about the great success of our P.C.A. [Pre-Columbian Art exhibition] in Paris. Wait for the new catalogs from Stokohlm [*sic*] and you will realize that the road is paved for large business" (Guillermo Echániz to Alfred Stendahl, 3 Aug. 1952, SAGRb, b11f7). Indeed, visitors to the Stockholm exhibition vied for this catalogue and related prints and publications (fig. 3).



Fig. 3: Visitors in Stockholm, Sweden, vying for catalogues at the exhibition "Mexican Art: from Pre-Colombian Times to the Present Day" (1952), directed by Fernando Gamboa. Photographer: Kary H. Lasch. Property of "Promotora Cultural Fernando Gamboa, A.C."

Despite the exhibition's inarguable success, it was not without its critics in Mexico. In 1954 the journalist Mario Escurdia published a scathing exposé on what he considered the outsized importance and unethical practices of Mexico's private collectors and dealers, as well as their associates abroad—named chiefly among them were Guillermo Echániz and Earl Stendahl (Escurdia 1954, 92–98). It was within this context that Escurdia lamented how Gamboa, for his 1952 show, "hubo de solicitar muchas de las obras exhibidas a coleccionistas particulares, en calidad de préstamo*"* (had to request many of the materials on exhibit from private collectors, as loans) (Escurdia 1954, 96). However, if Gamboa sought materials from private collections to enrich public collections in state-funded exhibitions, Stendahl sought state funding for exhibitions that were largely drawn from private collections—and for his own commercial gain. Stendahl was a keen observer of a broad range of Mexican cultural programming, and in much the same way as he approached Mexico's archaeological sites and collections, he did not hesitate to extract profitable ideas from Mexico's cultural practitioners.

Exhibition Politics

Writing from New York City in 1955, Earl reported to his son Alfred the progress of his negotiations with USIA as he sought support for what would become an eight-venue European tour held between 1958 and 1960. He wrote (Earl Stendahl to Alfred Stendahl, undated [probably 1955], SAGRb, b105f8):

> "Had [...] three or for [*sic*] days
> with the USIA They were tremendously interested in
> what I had to offer and want to study it in more
> detail. The only stumbling block is the fact that
> they have to put up a great deal of money for an
> individual. If we could work throu [*sic*] a non profit
> orginazition [*sic*] it could be done."

Stendahl was insistent, and while in Berlin in 1956, he met with the head of Amerika Häuser (Earl Stendahl to Alfred Stendahl, 7 Sept. 1956, SAGRb, b105f8)—a USIA-funded network that advanced the agency's mission among German-speaking audiences. Although official confirmation that the SAG received the $98,500 in funding requested in their application has not

yet been surfaced,[5] it is likely that they secured the money, as the exhibition proceeded soon after the application was submitted. Its first iteration opened in October 1958 at the Haus der Kunst in Munich.

Stendahl's campaign was supported by the partnership forged with Peter Ade, who, as Director of the Haus der Kunst, represented the "non profit orginization [*sic*]" based in Europe working in tandem with the AFA, as the participation of non-governmental and non-commercial collaborators was required to secure the US Government backing. In a letter to his son Alfred, Earl expressed particular enthusiastism for Ade's involvement, noting that he was well-connected to "the most important live people on the continent [who were] considered the art center of all activities" (Earl Stendahl to Alfred Stendahl, 14 Sept. [1956], SAGRb, b105f8). More revealing still was Earl's assessment of Ade's political leverage: holding "great influence with the U.S. Ambassadors and if nessarry [*sic*] will use it" (Earl Stendahl to Alfred Stendahl, 14 Sept. [1956], SAGRb, b105f8). Indeed, perhaps both as payment for his role in organizing the exhibition and anticipating how such political connections might reinforce his standing, Stendahl granted Ade a 5% commission on all exhibition-derived sales (Earl Stendahl to Alfred Stendahl and Joseph Dammann, 30 Jan. 1959, SAGRb, b105f7), a relatively modest arrangement given the pivotal role that he ultimately played in the Stendahls' establishment, and lasting presence, in Europe. In fact, long after the exhibition tour concluded, the Stendahls successfully continued to expand their transatlantic business selling pre-Columbian art and sourcing antiquities and paintings across the continent (see King et al., forthcoming; O'Neil and Miller 2023).

At the same time, Ade was pursuing a cultural-political agenda of his own, one that bears a striking reciprocity with Stendahl's own intentions and proposed solutions. Under his post-war leadership, the Haus der Kunst sought to rehabilitate both its institutional identity and Germany's international reputation through cultural diplomacy. Constructed in the classical style and inaugurated on 18 July 1937—the same year that Picasso painted *Guernica*—under the Nazi regime as the *Haus der deutschen Kunst* (House of German Art), the museum stood just a block away from an annex of the former Institute of Archaeology, where the notorious *Die Ausstellung "Entartete Kunst"* (*Degenerate Art*) exhibition opened the following day

[5] Despite our best efforts, we have not located information pertaining to Stendahl's proposal in the National Archives because USIA records pertaining to the 1950s are incomplete and were not maintained in a centralized filing system (National Archives and Records Administration, pers. comm. 22 Jun. 2026).

(Schuhmacher 2026; Knell 2016, 91; Petropoulos 1996, 57).[6] Assembled from artworks confiscated from German museums after 1933, the exhibition denigrated modern art while drawing enormous public audiences (Knell 2016, 91). In the 1950s, Ade sought to redress this history by reuniting the institution with Modernism, which it had previously played a role in lambasting (Haus der Kunst München 2012). His efforts materialized in a series of landmark exhibitions, most notably the 1955 Picasso retrospective, which brought *Guernica* to Munich—and to Germany—for the first time (fig. 4) (Haus der Kunst München 2012; Haus der Kunst München 1955).



Fig. 4: Visitors to the Haus der Kunst, Munich, in front of *Guernica*, 1955. Stadtarchiv, Munich: RD0833B06. © 2026 Estate of Pablo Picasso / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York.

By the end of 1958, Enid Stendahl wrote to the family expressing concern over the "Berlin Situation" (Enid Stendahl to Stendahl Family, 19 Dec. [1958], SAGRb, b106f5), a period of mounting tension that would culminate in 1961 with the erection of the Berlin Wall, a physical

[6] For a treatment on the "cultural bureaucracy" of the Nazi party, which is relevant to but beyond the scope of this chapter—specifically, anti-modernism, the foundation of the Haus der deutschen Kunst, and the *"Entartete Kunst"* exhibition—see Petropoulos' detailed chapter in its entirety, "Degenerate Art and State Interventionism, 1936–1938" (Petropoulos 1996, 51–74).

and ideological manifestation of the division between the communist East and the capitalist West. In 1959, Gamboa returned to Europe with his new show, *Arte mexicano antiguo y moderno* (*Ancient and Modern Mexican Art*)*,* even exhibiting alongside Stendahl at certain venues, much to the discomfort of both (O'Neil and Miller 2023). Their concurrent exhibitions also raised eyebrows in Mexico, with observers such as the art collector Alvar Carrillo Gil arguing, in an article preserved by the Stendahls in their archive, that the exhibitions—and their catalogues—were drumming up the market for Mexican antiquities in Europe, driving prices sky high and robbing Mexico of its national patrimony (Carrillo Gil 1959, SAGRb, b119f6; see also n. 4 herein).

QUETZALCOATL ET XOCHIPILLI

LES deux ministres qui ont inauguré hier l'exposition d'art précolombien à la galerie Charpentier, Jacques Soustelle et André Malraux, figurent parmi la poignée des compétences qui, dans le monde entier, peuvent parler de l'art aztèque et de la civilisation maya.

Chacun de son côté, ils parcouraient les salles. André Malraux, avec son visage ravagé de colonel-poète, de Vigny à mèche de Bonaparte, soucieux, disert, surpris, surprenant, toujours prêt à bavarder avec un chef-d'œuvre.

— *C'est merveilleux, votre exposition*, disait-il à Raymond Nacenta. *Jamais on n'a réuni autant d'œuvres belles ou typiques et il y a là dix merveilles.*

Il allait de salle en salle, de stand en stand, d'une civilisation à l'autre, comme dans un de ses livres. Il se heurta tout à coup à un animal fabuleux désigné dans le catalogue comme « probablement un ours », ce qui était discuté par quelques compétences.

— *En effet*, dit-il, *un ours à longue queue, c'est étrange. Appelons plutôt cela : « espèce disparue, origine prolétarienne ».*

Puis, plus loin, devant une terre cuite qui représente un coyote ou un chien, il décida :

— *C'est un chien. Et s'il y a une délégation de coyotes qui proteste, envoyez-la moi. J'ai l'habitude.*

Soustelle, orné, comme Malraux, du simple ruban de la Libération, sans mèche, plus massif, moins à facettes mais plus rond, professeur du genre qui ne tire pas sur ses élèves, donne volontiers toutes les explications qu'on lui demande.

— *Voyez-vous ces poteries mayas ? Elles sont décorées d'hiéroglyphes, mais qui, ici, ne veulent rien dire : ce sont de simples graphismes ornementaux. Mais oui, les Mayas avaient une écriture, qu'on sait déchiffrer... en partie. En tout cas, c'est grâce à cela que leur civilisation est celle que nous*



connaissons le mieux. D'ailleurs, ils s'extériorisent, ils racontent leur vie quotidienne, ils décrivent leur costume. Voyez ces vitrines : ici, cette marchande de poissons assise, sans doute au marché, attendant un client. Là, ce personnage bardé de vêtements et de survêtements, avec, sur la tête, une sorte de turban turc énorme : une manière de mamamouchi.

Après les propos des ministres, je commence à avoir quelques lueurs. Je sais que les Aztèques, les seuls que l'on connaissait jusqu'au début de notre siècle, sont les conquérants qui ont effacé les civilisations antérieures. On a retrouvé depuis, du Mexique à Panama, les Mayas, les Zapotèques, les Olmèques et tous ceux qu'on appelle, faute de mieux, les « archaïques », qui remontent jusqu'à mille ans avant notre ère. Je sais que Quetzalcoatl est le serpent à

Lire demain dans la rubrique des arts l'article de Raymond Cogniat.

plumes et Xochipilli le prince des fleurs.

Mais, comme tous les néophytes, je veux en apprendre davantage. Je trouve un nouveau guide bénévole. Mme Soustelle, qui travaille au musée de l'Homme, qui prépare une thèse de doctorat et qui a écrit la préface du catalogue.

— *Dix pièces extraordinaires*, a dit M. Malraux ? *Peut-être. Mais peut-être aussi quinze ou vingt. Vous avez vu le masque de mosaïque du trésor de Montezuma donné par Ferdinand Cortès à Charles Quint, par Charles Quint probablement au pape ; la poignée du couteau de sacrifice, le propulseur enrichi d'or, le vase à pulpe décoré d'une tête, la tête de mort en cristal de roche, telle qu'on n'en connaît que deux dans le monde ; celle-ci est à Paris, au musée de l'Homme, beaucoup plus riche qu'on ne croit. Pour les dates, on se trompe sans doute. Des procédés détectant la radio-activité des matières organiques permettent de préciser l'âge des terres cuites et des poteries. On en apprend d'ailleurs tous les jours. Dans ma préface, écrite il y a trois semaines, j'ai fixé le début de la civilisation maya à 300 ans après J.-C. Eh bien ! on vient de découvrir un objet antérieur de quelques années.*

Mme Soustelle rit de son ignorance... relative.

— *Que voulez-vous, ce qu'il y a de passionnant dans l'archéologie, c'est que la science se fait tous les jours, que ce qu'on apprend aujourd'hui contredit ce que l'on croyait hier.*

L'après-midi, l'art précolombien fut livré aux femmes du monde de Paris. On entendit moins de remarques pertinentes, mais on ne pouvait plus approcher des vitrines de bijoux.

Jean Fayard.

JEAN LEC FAIT DES TOILES

Malgré le temps pluvieux, M. Jean Lec est actuellement exposé. A la Galerie Royale. Mais qu'on ne tire point de conclusions hâtives de son apparition parmi les chevaliers de la palette. M. Lec n'est pas un peintre du dimanche. Non !... La trêve dominicale est un trop bon jour pour les chansonniers... M. Lec, à l'inverse de tant d'autres amateurs, peint la semaine. Et des tours Eiffel de préférence. Pas tellement par goût, à ce qu'il paraît, mais pour une raison d'économie sans subtilité : il habite le Champ de Mars.

Dix toiles de lui sont donc, depuis hier, offertes à l'admiration de la galerie. Parmi les dames qui veillaient pieusement devant l'œuvre du maître, j'ai reconnu Danielle Rocca. M. Lec commentait tristement sa peinture :

— *Regardez ce tableau ! Jamais le sable des Tuileries n'a été jaune comme cela, n'est-ce pas ? Toutes ces couleurs sortent de mon imagination. Et celui-là ! c'est un vase de fleurs posé devant ma fenêtre... Mais j'ai remplacé la tour Eiffel par le Sacré-Cœur pour changer un peu...*

Après cela, qui osera encore prétendre que M. Jean Lec demeure prisonnier de la triste réalité ?

Ph. B.

FACTEURS DE BAISSE ...ET DE CADEAUX

La rive gauche a connu hier, dès la matinée, l'animation de ses grands soirs. Mais le touriste avait cédé la place à l'habitant du quartier. La musique de la Garde républicaine, venue en voisine, inaugura, en effet, à coups d' « airschoc », la quinzaine commerciale « Seine-Buci-Dauphine », qui s'inscrit dans le cadre de la réhabilitation de la libre concurrence. Les prix-choc (10 à 20 % de baisse en moyenne) fleurissaient à tous les éventaires.

Atmosphère de dimanche matin. Les ménagères, filet au bras, échangeaient leurs (bonnes) impressions :

— *Qui est-ce ? Vous les connaissez ?*

Il s'agissait du cortège officiel. Il y avait aussi cinq facteurs (en costume d'opérette) qui distribuaient des enveloppes contenant

Fig. 5: Jean Fayard and Piem. "Deux Ministres Devant: Quetzalcoatl et Xochipilli" and cartoon panel. © Le Figaro 16 May 1959. First cited in SAGRb, b119f10.

Whatever diplomatic cover Stendahl claimed for his exhibition, European critics saw straight through it. The enterprise, as they recognized it, was an arbitrage operation dressed up as cultural altruism: French cartoonist Piem exposed this underbelly in an acerbic vignette on Stendahl's 1959 exhibition at Galerie Charpentier in Paris (fig. 5), a critique further elaborated by Italian critic Marcello Venturoli in his review of the exhibition's 1960 iteration in Rome, *Arte Precolombiana del Messico e dell'America Centrale (Pre-Columbian Art from Mexico and Central America)*:

> […] of the artworks exhibited, many have been tacitly for put up for sale, thus mixing scientific and educational interests with those of the market; the Exhibition is also a convenient base for a U.S. antiquities dealer, who sells his Mexican fragments in Italy and, with the proceeds, buys whatever can be bought in Italy, from the Etruscans on, in order to resell this new merchandise in the United States, where it is in higher demand and where the prices can be raised to a greater extent than here" (translation of Venturoli 1960, 3).

Ventruoli picked up on the structure that underpinned the purpose of the exhibition: leveraging public funding and cultural spectacle to open a transatlantic market, with the art of the ancient Americas serving as both the lure and the currency. And, in a turn of delicious irony, the negative press may itself have been planted *against* Stendahl, as mused by artist and collector Eugene Berman in a note that accompanied the newspaper clipping that he forwarded to Stendahl: "one very hostile article in the pro – communist Paese Sera, obviously inspired by recent talks with Gamboa (who was here [in Rome] not long ago) and is directed against the "commercial" angle of the exhibit" (Eugene Berman to Earl Stendahl, 26 Nov. 1960, SAGRb, b9f16).

Stendahl's tour concluded at the end of 1960, but Gamboa regrouped for *Obras maestras del arte mexicano* (*Masterworks of Mexican Art*), which opened in the USSR in 1961 and closed in the United States in 1964. Whereas Stendahl's initiative framed pre-Hispanic culture within a distinctly anti-Soviet framework, Gamboa employed Mexico's cultural patrimony to cultivate diplomatic and cultural relations on both sides of the Iron Curtain.

Conclusions

The 1956 application that Stendahl submitted to USIA was less a departure from his earlier exhibition practice than an extension—or intensification—of it. In 1939, *Guernica* provided the SAG with a politically charged spectacle through which controversy ("insanity in art") could be converted into publicity. Despite the fact that journalist Alma May Cook, a friend and associate of Stendahl (see King, fig. 3, in this volume), denied that the "discussion [...] was […] started as 'publicity' for the current showing of Picasso canvases" (Cook, 12 Aug. 1939, SAGRa, b1f12), Stendahl's participation was clearly not an expression of a straightforward political solidarity, or even charitable goodwill; rather, he required a $200 fee to host the painting, when other gallerists had agreed to do so for free (Marcelene Peterson to Evelyn Ahrend, 20 Jul. 1939 and 2 Sept. 1939, SRRAR 1935-1957, Part B, box 25). Two decades later, pre-Hispanic art became the material culture through which Stendahl sought to convert Cold War politics into commercial opportunity. The Haus der Kunst renders this continuity especially visible: when Peter Ade brought *Guernica* to Munich in 1955, the painting helped recast an institution implicated in the Nazi condemnation of modernism as a site of post-war repair and cultural exchange. Just three years later, Stendahl's exhibition tour was inaugurated at that same institution, a setting in which contemporary cultural politics were undeniably linked to public exhibitions, circumstances that enabled Stendahl to likewise leverage in marketing pre-Hispanic art.

But *Guernica* offers more than a point of departure and return. Its passage through Stendahl's gallery at the outset of the war and the Haus der Kunst in the post-war period evinces the consideration of a broader history in which exhibitions transformed art into instruments of both persuasion and exchange, and political meanings superimposed on cultural objects could be leveraged for both ideological and commercial ends—in Stendahl's case, with cunning symbiosis. This dynamic remains pertinent in the twenty-first century: the dual display of Picasso's *Guernica* and Dumile Feni's *African Guernica* at the Reina Sofía in Madrid in 2026 (Museo Nacional Centro de Arte Reina Sofía 2026) underscores the continuing need to confront the legacies and consequences of power imbalances, cultural extraction, and appropriation, as well as commodification, circulation, and curation.

Note on Translations

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